

Charno refused to return the money and Sukhdev reported the matter to the local police. Four women, Kartaro, Charno, Rani and Guddi were subsequently arrested.

For Sukhdev and his family, the only consolation is that they are one among many such families being duped into marrying "fake wives". Police sources say there could be over 30 such gangs operating in rural Haryana, whose modus operandi is the same: lure the family into the trap by showing them young, attractive girls, charge a bounty to get the marriage

Ludhiana. The girl stayed with her new husband for two weeks before disappearing with cash and jewellery. Kaur and Ram Singh, who had got their cut, were apprehended and negotiated a deal which led to the arrest of Proti Bai. Kaur, however, is still under the scanner.

So far, by her own admission, she has organised two such fake marriages where the "bride" vanished with money and valuables. In an earlier instance, she provided a bride to Mahaveer Bishnoi of Hisar district.

These gangs manage to survive since it is a low risk affair. The cheated parties rarely go to the police as honour and pride are paramount and the shame of being duped by a woman forces them to conceal the incident from relatives and neighbours. Says Inspector General of Police, Hisar range, Anant Kumar Dhull: "Despite being cheated, they do not report the matter to the police fearing social stigma." The usual alibi given by those swindled is that the girl in question was of a doubtful character so they sent her back to her family. Sukhdev did not



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ANANT KUMAR DHULL, IG, HISAR

fixed and finally produce a fake wife and pocket the money paid by the desperate groom. In another variation, the fake wives actually live with the new "husbands" till they get an opportunity to clear out with valuables. This came to light in another recent case where two middlemen, Ram Singh of village Dhaba in Sirsa and Parminder Kaur of Ratiya in Fatehabad, who used to provide brides for money, helped police apprehend another gang of fake wives. Kaur and Ram Singh made the error of duping a retired policeman who had been widowed and wanted to remarry. Kaur fixed his marriage with the help of Proti Bai, a resident of

THE FACILITATOR: Parminder Kaur at a police station in Sirsa

When the girl tried to flee with the money, she was caught by the family who said they would release her only if the money they paid was returned. The police have now taken up the case. Ram Prasad, assistant inspector in the Sirsa police station, where the case is registered, says the arrested woman, Jyoti, 35, is married and has children. "She came here to make some money," he adds. Prasad says most of these women are actually sex workers whose value drops after a certain age. They are then supplied as 'fake wives'.

have an option. The whole *baraat* was witness to the fraud.

The larger issue, of course, is the skewed sex ratio which plays a major role in encouraging the fake wife racket. Women play a pivotal role in the rural life of Haryana; they work in the house, the fields, bring up children, cook and clean, which explains why men here are so desperate to marry. The problem is compounded by growing unemployment and average land holdings becoming smaller, leading to increased poverty.

Lack of money coupled with lack of wives is proving to be quite a dangerous cocktail. ■